

LITTLE SPROUT STORIES

Marcus & James Visit the Doctor

A story about feeling anxious — and the power of a small choice



Marcus had a checkup today, and just thinking about it made his tummy feel fluttery, like a jar full of butterflies had come loose inside him. Beside him sat James, his very best friend, who had come along to help — and James loved facts the way some people love ice cream.

Marcus goes to the doctor.



The door opened, and in came Dr. Patel, with a smile that made the whole room feel warmer. “Hello, Marcus. Hello, James,” she said. “I’m Dr. Patel. Would you like to see what a doctor’s day is really like — and everything we do to keep people healthy?”

Dr. Patel says hello.



“Before my first patient,” said Dr. Patel, “I get everything ready.” She washed her hands until they were squeaky clean, laid out fresh paper on the examining table, and checked her tools one by one. “A doctor’s first job isn’t fixing sickness. It’s being clean, calm, and ready — before anyone even walks in.”

Dr. Patel gets her tools ready.



James’s eyes went round. “Facts!” he announced, and Dr. Patel showed them every one: the stethoscope that listens to hearts, the little ear-light that peeks inside ears, the soft cuff that gives your arm a gentle hug to measure how strongly your heart pushes, and the tall scale that tells how much you’ve grown. “Every tool answers a question,” Dr. Patel said. “My job is knowing which question to ask.”

Dr. Patel has tools that listen and look.



In the corner sat a very patient patient — a teddy bear with a bandage on his paw. “Doctors practice too,” said Dr. Patel, listening carefully to the teddy’s pretend heartbeat. “We study for many, many years, and we keep practicing on teddies and pretend patients, so that when a real child needs us, our hands already know what to do.”

Doctors practice to be ready.



Out in the waiting room, the whole neighborhood seemed to be there: a baby getting her first checkup, a grandfather with a bandaged thumb, a nurse calling names in a kind voice, and a receptionist who knew everybody’s birthday. “A clinic isn’t just for sick days,” said Dr. Patel. “We help people stay healthy — with checkups, and vaccines, and good advice — all year long.”

The clinic helps the whole town stay healthy.



“The best visit,” Dr. Patel told them, “is the one where nothing is wrong at all.” She showed them the germ-fighting rules: wash your hands with soap and sing the whole birthday song, cover your coughs like a vampire with his cape, and give your body sleep and colorful foods. “Part of my job,” she said, “is teaching families how to not get sick in the first place.”

Wash your hands to stop germs.



James, who loved facts, started explaining every single step out loud. “First they’ll check your ears, then your heart, then your eyes, then your—” On and on he went, faster and faster, and with every single fact, Marcus’s flutter grew bigger and bigger, until it felt less like butterflies and more like a whole flock of flapping birds.

Marcus feels bad.

How does Marcus feel?

- ◯ Calm
- ◯ Anxious
- ◯ Silly



Dr. Patel noticed. She sat down so her eyes were right even with Marcus's, and she spoke slowly and softly. "Marcus," she said, "would it help if you picked the order we do things in? Your ears, your heart, your growing-check — you can choose what comes first."

Marcus can pick.



Marcus thought very carefully. “Ears first,” he said. “Heart last.” And just deciding — just having the plan be partly his — made the flutter shrink smaller and smaller. Dr. Patel peeked in his ears, friendly as could be, and last of all came the stethoscope, cool and gentle on his chest. Then Dr. Patel did something wonderful: she let Marcus listen to his own heartbeat too. Thump-thump. Thump-thump. Steady as a drum.

Marcus picks ears first.

What helped Marcus feel calm?

- ◯ Having no plan
- ◯ Having a choice
- ◯ Being told to hurry



“That wasn’t so bad, when I got to choose,” Marcus said. Dr. Patel beamed. “You know my favorite part of this job? It isn’t the tools, and it isn’t the facts. It’s watching a worried face turn into a brave one — and knowing this town trusts me with the people it loves most.” Thump-thump, went Marcus’s heart, calm as could be.

Dr. Patel loves helping people feel better.



On the way out, James turned to Marcus with a very serious face. “Next time,” he promised, “I will ask before I explain. Asking first is a fact I should have known.” Marcus grinned. “That would help a lot.” And the two friends walked home together — one a little braver, one a little wiser, and both Healthy Helpers.

James will ask first.



■ Healthy Helper

Great reading!

For Grown-Ups

Feeling/skill: Anxiety eases when a child is offered a small, real choice.

Ask your child: What is one choice that would help you feel ready for something new?

Try this: Offer two small choices before your child's next appointment.

Words to grow on: fluttery, checkup, stethoscope, gentle, steady, choice, anxious, trust. Point at the tools as you name them — stethoscope, ear-light (otoscope), blood-pressure cuff, scale.

The bigger picture: Doctors do much more than treat sickness — they prepare and clean their rooms and tools before every patient, study and practice for years (often on pretend patients first), work as a team with nurses and receptionists, give checkups and vaccines to keep people healthy, and teach families the everyday habits that stop illness before it starts.

Standards: L.K.1.d, SL.K.2

The End — thanks for reading!